What can you turn?

A better question would be 'what can't you turn'? As you think about alternatives to the traditional woods for turning, you'll need to know what your tools can cut. With the commonly used high-speed steel tools, you'll be able to cut just about anything that isn't hardened. Your high-speed steel tools are the same cutting material that a machinist uses on a metal-cutting lathe. The only real difference is that his cutting tool is locked rigidly into a tool post and yours is hand controlled. Other than that, your high-speed cutters or carbide tools will work on materials that could be cut by a machinist. How can you tell for sure, especially with metals? Take a file and try to file the material. If it cuts with a file, it is soft enough to be turned on your wood lathe. If the file skates across the material without cutting it, it is a hardened material beyond your tool's ability to cut it.

Tagua nuts

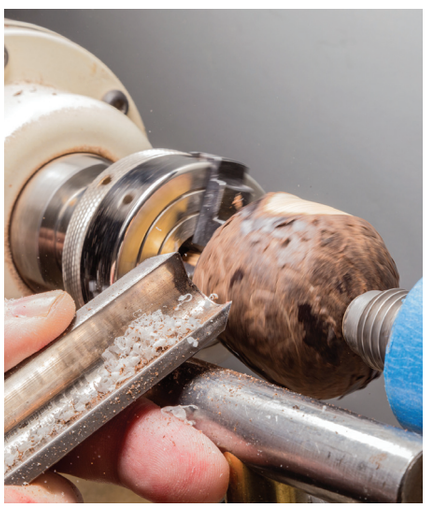
Tagua nuts are the seed of a tree similar to a palm but technically a different species. I've heard the name pronounced in many ways with the most common variations being 'tag-goo-ah', 'tah-gwah' and 'tau-gew-ah'. I am not certain which of these, if any, is correct but one of them will convey your thoughts.

Often called a palm nut, vegetable ivory, ivory nut, or faux ivory, it has been used for many years to create buttons and hand-carved items. It grows in the tropical rainforests of South America and is readily available through the craft marketing circles. Having become an alternative to animal ivory, the turning community has adopted it for small turnings and adornment where the appearance of ivory would be attractive. The biggest problem that tagua nuts present is that they are hollow. The internal cavity is often irregularly shaped and can be located anywhere. When turning regularly shaped lidded boxes or other similar items, this internal void can be troublesome.

The nut can be mounted between centres to create a small tenon for mounting or have a sacrificial block attached with adhesive. The easiest way to do this is by sanding a flat and using that flat to attach your mounting block. Turning and sanding is a breeze. Both cutting and scraping tools will allow you to hollow and shape the tagua material to your desired shape. Sanding is exactly as you would do on a softer species of wood. The outer dark, hard shell can be cut away entirely or left partial depending on your end goal. The nut itself cuts like soap being soft and easily cut with sharp tools. My typical use is to slice the nut to provide accent pieces to be glued to my turning. This allows the 'ivory accent' to be integrated into drawer pulls, lidded box pulls, and finials for boxes and ornaments. I find that using two-part epoxy when adhering tagua nut material to other woods works best. You can also use hot melt glue to fasten things provided you'll be using a light enough touch. The fun part of tagua turned material is the ability to accept dyes. Give any of your dyes a try. I find my Jacquard silk dyes work nicely.

Tagua nuts are available in a variety of shapes, sizes and freshness. The internal colour seems to vary with age

The nut's internal void is irregular in shape and placement which can potentially present issues with turning projects



Tagua nuts cut very nicely with sharp tools and are sanded exactly as wood...

... they're also easily mounted on a dowel, sanded flat with glue block, or a small turned tenon...

...and fun can be had colouring them. They take readily to dyeing with most art dye brands

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